

of miles away. Be it the Andhra Pradesh Minority Welfare Minister Mohammed Ahmedullah, women's organisations or the clerics, everyone exerted pressure on the fractious families to make peace and liberate Banjara Hills from the TV tribe.

An MOU was drafted which made Malik concede and give Siddiqui a written divorce. It also announced the payment of token maintenance to Ayesha—Rs 5,000 a month for three months as per Sharia. The cases made against Malik were withdrawn, the divorce signed in the presence of a qazi.

In her tweets of the weekend,

when the Malik-Siddiqui confrontation had hit its peak, Mirza wrote, "I am pretty sure these are not the pre-wedding jitters or butterflies in the stomach my married cousins were talking about! Leaves me with no choice but to laugh! Haven't slept all night... again lots to do and face."

Mirza has faced as much in these last few months as her Pakistani fiancé. The Hyderabad first broke off her public and dazzling engagement to family friend Sohrab Mirza and then suffered a wrist injury which has stopped her tennis. Across the border, Malik was banned for a year by the

Pakistani Cricket Board for indiscipline. Such an Indo-Pak pairing of the famous could have expected political problems but what happened last week soured into avoidable wedding woes. Much of it was Malik's creation.

This even when the story about Malik's life earlier was fairly public and even the Mirzas knew. After something like a cyberspace romance between strangers, Malik married Siddiqui on June 3, 2002, whether in person or the phone is still not authenticated. The marriage was then called off, but after three years. Like a bad penny with amnesia, Malik returned to

The Man on Permanent Shift

If controversy courts Mirza, both bad press and bad news follows her Pakistani beau

If you thought controversy followed Sania Mirza like a devoted puppy, then Shoaib Malik's cricket career moves on a 24x7 cycle of bad press. Not that it's all invented by bored tabloid hacks looking for instant fame. After the 2003 Test series against Bangladesh, the then captain Rashid Latif is believed to have written in his report asking the Pakistan Cricket Board to keep an eye on Malik as he kept slightly dubious company.

In 2005, he was fined around PRs 200,000 for throwing a domestic T20 game. Five years later, he is banned to "disciplinary breaches" on the tour of Australia. Even though he was highly praised by the late Bob Woolmer for having "tactical sharpness" and a good cricketing brain, his captaincy has always been a man management failure. He was replaced as captain in 2009 because team management formally reported that he was "aloof and a loner".

Malik has always been two people—more than once and the Siddiquis know how. In 2002, he went up to a wire services journalist and wanted the news of his June wedding be publicised. When it appeared in the Arab News, he thanked the journalist, saying "the girl's side is very happy". Two years later, on a Geo TV programme *Ek Din Geo Ke Saath*, he was asked about his female fan following, and replied, "I'm already married to an Indian based in Jeddah."

Mirza may just be the cache that Malik is looking for in social status and individual respectabil-

ity. The couple knew each other for several years but have grown closer from November onwards. Dropped from his team in Australia, Malik sought permission to leave his group and watch tennis regularly. Back then, no one knew why. As early as January, he was asking an Indian girl now settled in Karachi, about what life in Pakistan was like.

Even if all is well, it is not where Mirza will head in any case. Dubai is to be her home. In 2008, Malik won a tournament for his Dubai club in Canada; the prize included a residency visa for the UAE and an apartment in Ajman. It is said the couple will live in the Palm Jumeirah.



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